SNOWFLAKE + INFORMATICA IDMC

MASTER MOCK INTERVIEW GUIDE

Concept mastery • Implementation • Scenarios • Troubleshooting • Interview answers

Built around your Snowflake and IDMC training, practical mappings,
SCD, Lookup Cache, Pushdown Optimization, CDC, and end-to-end pipelines.

How to Use This Guide

This is an interviewer-led working manual, not a glossary. For every topic, learn the definition, execution behavior, use cases, trade-offs, failure modes, and validation evidence.

- First pass: understand the mechanism and key terms.
- Second pass: explain the concept aloud without looking at the notes.
- Third pass: answer the scenario before reading the suggested approach.
- For a production issue, do not guess a fix. Establish the symptom, inspect logs/metrics, isolate the layer, test one hypothesis, and validate the business result.

A mapping can validate and still process zero rows. A job can report success and still produce incorrect business data. Always validate row counts, key uniqueness, rejected records, and target results.

Interview Answer Framework

1. Definition: Give a precise one- or two-sentence definition.
2. Purpose: State what problem the feature solves.
3. Mechanism: Explain what happens during execution.
4. Use case: Connect it to a realistic pipeline.
5. Trade-off: Discuss cost, latency, correctness, maintainability, or complexity.
6. Validation: Name the log, query, metric, or output that proves it worked.

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1. Snowflake Architecture and Core Objects

1.1 Architecture

Snowflake separates storage, compute, and cloud services. Storage holds compressed data in internal micro-partitions. Virtual warehouses provide compute for query execution. The cloud services layer coordinates authentication, metadata, optimization, and other platform services. This separation allows compute to scale independently of stored data.

Layer	Responsibility	Interview focus
Storage	Persisted table data and metadata	Micro-partitions, pruning, retention.
Compute	Virtual warehouses execute queries and DML	Warehouse size, concurrency, suspend/resume.
Cloud services	Authentication, metadata, optimization, coordination	Do not assume every operation uses warehouse compute identically.

1.2 Core objects

Object	Purpose	Common mistake
Database	Container for schemas	Treating it as compute.
Schema	Namespace for tables, views, stages, policies, tasks	Ignoring schema privileges.
Warehouse	Compute resource for supported workloads	Assuming a larger warehouse fixes poor SQL.
Role	Bundle of privileges assigned to users/roles	Granting admin when usage is sufficient.
Stage	Location reference for files	Confusing a stage with a table.
File format	Parsing rules for CSV, JSON, Parquet, etc.	Mismatched delimiter, quoting, header, or NULL rules.
Stream	Change-data interface for a source object	Treating it as a full historical audit log.
Task	Scheduled or condition-driven SQL execution	Forgetting to resume a task.

1.3 Warehouses and scaling

- Scale up when a query is compute-bound or spills because it lacks resources. Verify this with Query Profile before resizing.
- Scale out with multi-cluster where concurrency and queueing are the problem. More clusters do not necessarily make one query faster.
- Separate workloads with different SLAs, such as ingestion, ELT, analytics, and development.
- Auto-suspend and auto-resume settings affect cost and latency. Tune them for the workload rather than copying a generic value.

1.4 Micro-partitions, pruning, and clustering

Snowflake stores table data in micro-partitions and maintains metadata that can eliminate irrelevant partitions. Pruning reduces data scanned when predicates align with the stored data organization. Clustering can help very large tables where natural organization is inadequate, but reclustering has cost and must be justified by evidence.

```
SELECT COUNT(*)
FROM SALES
WHERE ORDER_DATE >= '2026-01-01'
  AND ORDER_DATE <  '2026-02-01';
```

Do not claim that you will add a traditional B-tree index to optimize a standard Snowflake table. Discuss pruning, query shape, clustering when justified, warehouse sizing, and join cardinality.

1.5 Caching

Type	Meaning	Caution
Result cache	Reuses prior query results when Snowflake determines reuse is valid	Data changes or query conditions can prevent reuse.
Warehouse/local data cache	Warehouse may cache data read from storage	Suspension can affect local cache availability.
Metadata optimizations	Metadata can help optimize or answer some operations	Do not confuse metadata access with result caching.

Interviewer: Does a larger warehouse always make a query faster?

Strong answer: No. It helps only when available compute/resources are the bottleneck. Poor pruning, join explosion, unnecessary scans, external I/O, or queueing may require a different fix. Inspect Query Profile, bytes scanned, partitions scanned, spill, join cardinality, and queue time.

Likely follow-up: What evidence would justify a warehouse resize?

Interviewer: Scale up versus scale out?

Strong answer: Scale up increases a warehouse's compute size and may improve one query. Scale out with multi-cluster primarily addresses concurrency and queueing. Choose based on measured query latency versus concurrency.

Likely follow-up: Would you use multi-cluster to speed up one SQL statement? Usually not as the first remedy.

2. SQL, Modeling, and Data Quality

2.1 Logical query reasoning

A useful logical model is FROM/JOIN, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, SELECT, DISTINCT, ORDER BY, LIMIT. This is not the physical execution plan; the optimizer may reorder operations when semantics allow.

2.2 NULLs and conditional logic

```
SELECT
    CUSTOMER_ID,
    COALESCE(EMAIL, 'unknown@example.com') AS EMAIL_DISPLAY,
    IFF(STATUS IS NULL, 'UNKNOWN', STATUS) AS STATUS_NORMALIZED
FROM CUSTOMER;
```

- NULL is not zero, an empty string, or the text 'NULL'. Use IS NULL, not = NULL.
- COALESCE returns the first non-NULL expression. Ensure datatypes are compatible.
- NULL join keys do not match through ordinary equality.

2.3 Window functions and deduplication

```
SELECT *
FROM CUSTOMER_STAGING
QUALIFY ROW_NUMBER() OVER (
    PARTITION BY CUSTOMER_ID
    ORDER BY SOURCE_UPDATED_AT DESC, INGESTED_AT DESC
) = 1;
```

ROW_NUMBER assigns a unique sequence within each partition. The ordering must be deterministic, including tie-breakers. RANK preserves ties with gaps; DENSE_RANK preserves ties without gaps. Never deduplicate without defining which record wins.

2.4 MERGE and source uniqueness

```
MERGE INTO CUSTOMER_TARGET T
USING CUSTOMER_SOURCE S
  ON T.CUSTOMER_ID = S.CUSTOMER_ID
WHEN MATCHED THEN UPDATE SET
  T.EMAIL = S.EMAIL,
```

```
  T.STATUS = S.STATUS
WHEN NOT MATCHED THEN INSERT
  (CUSTOMER_ID, EMAIL, STATUS)
VALUES
  (S.CUSTOMER_ID, S.EMAIL, S.STATUS);
```

Before MERGE, ensure the source has at most one actionable row per target key unless the logic deliberately handles multiple source matches. Duplicate source keys can make updates nondeterministic or fail.

2.5 Dimensional modeling

Term	Meaning
Grain	What one row represents. Define before modeling.
Fact	Business event with measures and foreign keys.
Dimension	Descriptive entity used to filter/group facts.
Business key	Source/domain identifier, such as CUSTOMER_ID.
Surrogate key	Warehouse-generated identifier for a dimension row/version.
SCD1	Overwrite attributes; no old value retained in that row.
SCD2	Create version rows with effective dates/current flags.

Interviewer: Why did revenue double after a join?

Strong answer: The join may be many-to-many or a dimension may contain multiple matches per business key. Check row counts and key uniqueness before/after joins, validate grain, and join to the correct current/effective-dated row. Do not hide it with DISTINCT.

Likely follow-up: What would you check first: the SUM or the join keys? The join keys and cardinality.

Interviewer: COUNT(*) versus COUNT(column)?

Strong answer: COUNT(*) counts rows; COUNT(column) counts non-NULL values in that column.

Likely follow-up: What about COUNT(DISTINCT key)? It counts distinct non-NULL values of that expression.

3. Loading, Stages, COPY INTO, S3, Snowpipe

3.1 Loading flow

Typical flow: source/object storage → stage → file format → COPY INTO or Snowpipe → raw/staging table → validation and transformation. Track file counts, load status, rejected rows, target counts, and reconciliation at each boundary.

3.2 File format and COPY INTO

```
CREATE OR REPLACE FILE FORMAT CSV_FMT
  TYPE = CSV
  SKIP_HEADER = 1
  FIELD_OPTIONALLY_ENCLOSED_BY = '"'
  EMPTY_FIELD_AS_NULL = TRUE
  NULL_IF = ('NULL', 'null');

CREATE OR REPLACE TABLE RAW_EMP (
  EMPNO NUMBER,
  ENAME VARCHAR(100),
  SALARY NUMBER(12,2),
  DEPTNO NUMBER
);

COPY INTO RAW_EMP
FROM @MY_INTERNAL_STAGE/employee/
FILE_FORMAT = (FORMAT_NAME = CSV_FMT)
ON_ERROR = 'ABORT_STATEMENT';
```

This is a pattern, not a script to run blindly. Validate column order, delimiter, quoting, header, NULL representation, dates, permissions, stage path, and error policy.

3.3 Load validation

```
SELECT *
FROM TABLE(
  INFORMATION_SCHEMA.COPY_HISTORY(
    TABLE_NAME => 'RAW_EMP',
    START_TIME => DATEADD('hour', -24, CURRENT_TIMESTAMP())
  )
);

SELECT COUNT(*) AS ROW_COUNT FROM RAW_EMP;
```

Use the correct database/schema context and privileges. Account Usage surfaces may have latency and retention limits.

3.4 Snowpipe versus COPY

COPY INTO	Snowpipe
Controlled/batch loading and backfills; operator or orchestrator decides when to load.	Continuous, managed ingestion triggered by file arrival/notifications or supported ingestion mechanism.
Useful for scheduled batches and replay/backfill jobs.	Useful for lower-latency file-arrival ingestion.
Inspect COPY output and load history.	Inspect pipe status, notification path, and load history.

3.5 S3 integration

Prefer storage integrations and least-privilege cloud access over embedding long-lived cloud credentials. The trust relationship, external ID, allowed bucket/prefix, Snowflake integration, and AWS policy must agree. A syntactically valid IAM policy can still be functionally wrong.

Interviewer: A file is in S3, but COPY loads no rows. What do you inspect?

Strong answer: Check stage LIST output, path/pattern, storage integration, file format, target context, COPY output/history, whether the file was already loaded, and rejected rows. Compare file rows with loaded rows and confirm the file's actual header/delimiter/NULL representation.

Likely follow-up: Would you change the file format first? No. Gather evidence and isolate the mismatch.

Interviewer: When use Snowpipe instead of COPY?

Strong answer: Snowpipe fits automated file-arrival ingestion and low operational management. COPY fits controlled batches and backfills. Decide from latency, volume, cost, notification setup, replay behavior, and operating model.

4. Streams, CDC, Tasks, MERGE, Dynamic Tables

4.1 Streams and metadata

A stream exposes change data for a source object using an offset. It is not a full historical archive or separate copy of the source. Consuming changes in committed DML advances the offset. Exact behavior depends on stream type and source object.

Metadata	Interpretation
METADATA$ACTION	INSERT or DELETE change action.
METADATA$ISUPDATE	Helps identify delete/insert pairs that represent an update.
METADATA$ROW_ID	Row identifier metadata; not a substitute for a business key.

4.2 CDC design

For a standard stream, an update may appear as a DELETE and INSERT pair with update metadata. A delete should generally be treated as a real delete only when it is not the delete half of an update pair. Handle insert/update/delete according to source type, event ordering, and target requirements.

```
-- Illustrative logic only. Validate source columns and event ordering.
MERGE INTO CUSTOMER_TARGET T
USING CUSTOMER_STREAM S
  ON T.CUSTOMER_ID = S.CUSTOMER_ID
WHEN MATCHED
  AND S.METADATA$ACTION = 'DELETE'
  AND S.METADATA$ISUPDATE = FALSE
THEN DELETE
WHEN MATCHED
  AND S.METADATA$ACTION = 'INSERT'
THEN UPDATE SET
  T.NAME = S.NAME,
  T.STATUS = S.STATUS
WHEN NOT MATCHED
  AND S.METADATA$ACTION = 'INSERT'
THEN INSERT (CUSTOMER_ID, NAME, STATUS)
VALUES (S.CUSTOMER_ID, S.NAME, S.STATUS);
```

Do not copy CDC SQL without testing multiple events per key, source duplicates, ordering, delete semantics, and transaction behavior.

4.3 Tasks

Tasks run SQL or supported procedure calls on a schedule or condition. A task can exist without running: check state, schedule, condition, dependencies, warehouse/serverless configuration, grants, and task history.

```
CREATE OR REPLACE TASK CUSTOMER_CDC_TASK
  WAREHOUSE = COMPUTE_WH
  SCHEDULE = '1 MINUTE'
  WHEN SYSTEM$STREAM_HAS_DATA('CUSTOMER_STREAM')
AS
  INSERT INTO CDC_AUDIT (EVENT_TIME, NOTE)
  VALUES (CURRENT_TIMESTAMP(), 'CDC task executed');

ALTER TASK CUSTOMER_CDC_TASK RESUME;
```

The task body requires the audit table and correct privileges. Replace it with your intended MERGE/procedure and inspect task history.

4.4 Dynamic Tables versus Streams/Tasks

Pattern	Use when
Streams + Tasks	Explicit event handling, procedural logic, audit behavior, conditional execution, or controlled DML is needed.
Dynamic Tables	You want Snowflake to maintain a declarative query result toward a target freshness lag and the query pattern is supported.
Snowpipe	Automated file ingestion is the requirement.
IDMC Taskflow	Cross-system orchestration, branching, dependency management, and operational workflow are needed.

A robust incremental pipeline must account for duplicate delivery, retries, late changes, duplicate source keys, transaction boundaries, and restartability. Idempotency means replaying the same input does not corrupt the intended business state.

Interviewer: The stream is empty after a source update. How do you investigate?

Strong answer: Check the correct source/stream, change tracking, stream offset, transaction commit, whether another consumer committed and advanced the offset, and whether the source was recreated/replaced. Inspect task history and transaction outcomes.

Likely follow-up: Does an empty stream prove no source changes ever happened? No.

Interviewer: A task never runs. What do you check?

Strong answer: Resume status, schedule, condition, parent dependency, privileges, warehouse/serverless configuration, task history, and stream data. Test the underlying SQL independently.

Likely follow-up: Is task creation enough? No, state and prerequisites matter.

5. Time Travel, Fail-safe, Cloning, Table Types

Feature	Purpose	Distinction
Permanent table	Standard persistent table	Normal persistent data protection behavior.
Transient table	Persistent table without Fail-safe	Use only where recovery requirements permit.
Temporary table	Session-scoped table	Not available after session ends.
Time Travel	Query/restore historical data within configured retention	Retention depends on object/account configuration and edition.
Fail-safe	Snowflake-managed recovery mechanism for eligible permanent tables after Time Travel retention	Not a self-service historical query feature.
Zero-copy clone	Create a clone initially sharing underlying storage	Later changes can add storage.
Secure sharing	Share selected data without copying it to consumer account	Access controlled through provider/consumer grants.

```
-- Example Time Travel query; validate syntax and retention for your case
SELECT *
FROM CUSTOMER
AT (OFFSET => -300);

CREATE TABLE CUSTOMER_DEV CLONE CUSTOMER;
```

Interviewer: A table was dropped. What do you do?

Strong answer: Identify the object, drop time, privileges, and recovery window. If within applicable Time Travel retention, use supported UNDROP/recovery. If retention has passed, Fail-safe is not normal self-service SQL; follow the support and recovery process.

Likely follow-up: Why is Fail-safe not a backup strategy? It is a Snowflake-managed last-resort recovery mechanism, not an interactive historical query facility.

Interviewer: Would you use a transient table for irreplaceable raw data?

Strong answer: Only if its reduced recovery protection is explicitly acceptable. Choose table type based on reproducibility, criticality, retention, and recovery requirements, not a blanket assumption that transient is always better.

6. Performance, Monitoring, and Cost

6.1 Diagnosis order

7. Define the symptom: slow query, queued workload, expensive load, or poor freshness.
8. Capture baseline: elapsed time, queue time, bytes/partitions scanned, rows produced, warehouse, spill, and credits.
9. Inspect Query Profile for expensive scans, joins, sorts, aggregations, and spill.
10. Change one factor at a time and compare equivalent runs.
11. Validate output correctness and cost after every optimization.

Symptom	Potential cause	Investigation
High bytes scanned	Weak pruning, broad scan, unnecessary columns	Review predicates, partitions scanned, selected columns.
Join output balloons	Many-to-many join or duplicate keys	Check uniqueness, grain, and join

		cardinality.
Spilling	Intermediate data exceeds available resources	Inspect profile; improve query shape and test warehouse sizing.
Long queue	Concurrency/capacity issue	Separate queue time from execution; consider workload isolation.
Credits rise	Idle warehouse, retries, repeated scans/full refresh	Review warehouse settings, task loops, query patterns, cost per successful unit.

6.2 Monitoring surfaces

Surface	Use
Query History	SQL text, status, timing, warehouse, errors.
Query Profile	Operator-level execution and data flow.
Information Schema	Database/schema metadata and recent operational functions/views.
Account Usage	Account-level history, often with latency/retention constraints.
COPY/Load History	File ingestion status, load errors, rows.
Task History	Task execution state, duration, failures.
Access History	Where available and permitted, investigate object access.
Resource Monitor	Monitor/control credit usage within supported limits and actions.

Interviewer: A query takes 40 seconds and the warehouse is small. Resize?

Strong answer: Not before inspecting Query Profile. Determine whether time is execution or queueing; check pruning, join output, spill, and scans. Test a larger warehouse if compute-bound, but fix poor query shape or join explosion first.

Likely follow-up: How prove an optimization worked? Compare repeatable runs and correctness, noting cache effects.

Interviewer: How do you reduce Snowflake cost?

Strong answer: Attribute spend by warehouse/query/task; check auto-suspend, retries, warehouse sizing, concurrency, full refreshes/scans, and inefficient SQL. Add monitoring and measure cost per successful unit of work.

7. Snowflake Security

7.1 RBAC

Role-based access control assigns privileges to roles and roles to users or other roles. Apply least privilege. Users may need database USAGE, schema USAGE, table SELECT, and warehouse USAGE. Object ownership and routine usage are different privileges.

```
GRANT USAGE ON DATABASE TRAINING_DB TO ROLE ANALYST_ROLE;
GRANT USAGE ON SCHEMA TRAINING_DB.PUBLIC TO ROLE ANALYST_ROLE;
GRANT SELECT ON TABLE TRAINING_DB.PUBLIC.CUSTOMER TO ROLE ANALYST_ROLE;
GRANT USAGE ON WAREHOUSE COMPUTE_WH TO ROLE ANALYST_ROLE;
```

7.2 Masking versus row access

```
CREATE OR REPLACE MASKING POLICY EMAIL_MASK
AS (VAL STRING) RETURNS STRING ->
  CASE
    WHEN CURRENT_ROLE() IN ('PII_ADMIN') THEN VAL
    ELSE '***MASKED***'
  END;

ALTER TABLE CUSTOMER
  MODIFY COLUMN EMAIL SET MASKING POLICY EMAIL_MASK;

CREATE OR REPLACE ROW ACCESS POLICY REGION_POLICY
AS (REGION STRING) RETURNS BOOLEAN ->
  CASE
```

```
    WHEN CURRENT_ROLE() IN ('DATA_ADMIN') THEN TRUE
    WHEN CURRENT_ROLE() = 'NORTH_ROLE' AND REGION = 'NORTH' THEN TRUE
    WHEN CURRENT_ROLE() = 'SOUTH_ROLE' AND REGION = 'SOUTH' THEN TRUE
    ELSE FALSE
  END;

ALTER TABLE SALES
  ADD ROW ACCESS POLICY REGION_POLICY ON (REGION);
```

These examples demonstrate the mechanism, not a complete enterprise policy. Account for role hierarchy, authorized roles, policy ownership, data types, and governance requirements. Masking controls displayed column values; row access controls visible rows.

Interviewer: A user can query the database but gets a table authorization error. What do you check?

Strong answer: Active role, role hierarchy, database/schema USAGE, table SELECT, warehouse USAGE, ownership, future grants if relevant, and correct object context. Verify the active role rather than assuming the default role is active.

Interviewer: Why is an administrator unexpectedly filtered by a row access policy?

Strong answer: The policy may not include the active role, role inheritance may differ from assumptions, or the policy may be attached to an unexpected column/object. Test with explicit roles and inspect the definition and attachment.

8. IDMC Architecture and Mapping Fundamentals

8.1 Architecture and components

Component	Role
IDMC cloud services	Design-time metadata, configuration, monitoring, orchestration.
Secure Agent/runtime	Executes supported jobs and connects to endpoints.
Connection	Endpoint and authentication configuration.
Mapping	Source-to-target data flow and transformation logic.
Mapping Task	Execution configuration for a mapping.
Taskflow	Orchestrates tasks, dependencies, decisions, and error paths.
Monitor/logs	Run status, statistics, errors, runtime evidence.

Exact execution behavior depends on the service, connector, transformation support, runtime, and pushdown configuration. Do not overgeneralize across connectors.

8.2 Validation versus correctness

A valid mapping can still process zero rows, use the wrong source, route all rows away, write to the wrong target, or produce incorrect values. Check source counts, transformation counts, rejects, logs, target schema/object, write mode, and output data.

8.3 Zero-row diagnostic sequence

12. Verify the exact mapping task, runtime, connection, environment parameters, source object/query, and source row count.
13. Inspect filter conditions and NULL behavior; verify Router groups and default path.
14. Inspect Lookup no-match behavior, join conditions, and rejected rows.
15. Check field mappings, target object, target write mode, constraints, and transaction outcome.
16. Compare rows read, transformed, rejected, and written. Use a known test row to isolate the boundary.

Interviewer: A mapping validates and succeeds but target rows are zero. What do you do?

Strong answer: Treat it as a data-flow problem. Verify source data and connection, inspect filters/lookups/joins/Router paths, review job statistics and rejected rows, and confirm target context and write behavior. Isolate with a known input row.

Likely follow-up: What does a green status prove? Execution status, not necessarily business correctness.

Interviewer: Why might development work while production fails?

Strong answer: Different connections, schema/parameters, data distribution, privileges, runtime or connector versions, code page/time zone, target constraints, or pushdown support. Compare deployed metadata and runtime settings.

9. IDMC Transformations

9.1 Expression

Expression derives row-level values: trim/case normalization, flags, key preparation, validation, NULL handling, and calculations. Exact function syntax and support depend on the IDMC expression language and transformation mode.

```
-- Illustrative logic; adapt exact syntax to the tenant/runtime
CLEAN_EMAIL = LOWER(TRIM(EMAIL))
CLEAN_SEGMENT = UPPER(TRIM(CUSTOMER_SEGMENT))
VALID_CUSTOMER = IIF(
    ISNULL(CUSTOMER_ID) OR TRIM(CUSTOMER_ID) = '',
    0,
    1
)
```

NULL handling must be explicit. Do not substitute defaults unless they represent valid business logic.

9.2 Filter, Router, Aggregator, Joiner, Sorter, Rank

Transformation	Use	Common failure
Filter	Pass rows meeting a condition	False/NULL condition can eliminate rows; not for deduplication.
Router	Split one stream into condition-based paths	Overlapping or incomplete groups; unclear default path.
Aggregator	Group rows and calculate SUM/COUNT/MIN/MAX	Wrong grain, duplicate inputs, confusing COUNT(*) with COUNT(field).
Joiner	Combine pipelines on join keys	Many-to-many multiplication, wrong join type, unmatched rows lost.
Sorter	Order rows for downstream needs	Unnecessary sorting costs memory/time; table order is not guaranteed.
Rank	Top/bottom selection by group and sort criteria	Missing tie-breaker or unclear winner rule.

Interviewer: Router or multiple Filters?

Strong answer: Router is useful when one input should branch into several managed business paths. Separate filters may be clearer for independent flows. Decide based on readability, overlap/default handling, and execution requirements.

Interviewer: Aggregator totals are inflated. What do you inspect?

Strong answer: Group-by ports and intended grain, duplicate input rows, upstream join multiplication, datatypes, and whether counts include NULLs. Compare a hand-calculated subset.

Interviewer: How do you deduplicate correctly?

Strong answer: Define the winning record using source timestamp, sequence, source priority, or another business rule. Use Rank/ROW_NUMBER-like logic where supported. Do not pick an arbitrary first row.

10. Lookup Transformation and Cache

10.1 Lookup purpose

Lookup retrieves reference attributes by matching incoming rows to a lookup source. Examples: find a customer surrogate key, check whether a product exists, retrieve the current SCD row, or translate a source code. Define match key, expected cardinality, no-match behavior, duplicate handling, and freshness.

Connected Lookup	Unconnected Lookup
Participates in the main row flow and exposes configured output ports.	Invoked from an expression-like context and typically returns one configured return value.
Useful when several lookup attributes are needed in the row pipeline.	Useful for targeted calls, but repeated calls can add overhead.
Configured cache/conditions apply to the transformation.	Do not assume it is automatically faster or cheaper.

10.2 Cache types

Cache	Behavior	Caution
Static	Built and unchanged during the mapping run.	Good for reference data that does not need row-by-row cache updates.
Dynamic	Can update cache as rows are processed for supported patterns.	Order, key uniqueness, and update behavior matter.
Persistent	May be retained and reused across runs when supported/configured.	Freshness and invalidation must be managed.
Shared	Can be shared across compatible lookup transformations where supported.	Verify compatibility and product-specific constraints.
No cache	Lookup is performed without a reusable cache.	Can reduce cache memory but increase source calls/runtime.

10.3 Cache memory failures

Memory pressure depends on row count, row width, cache/index overhead, number of concurrent caches, concurrent jobs, and Secure Agent capacity. Row count alone is not enough.

- Project only columns needed by the mapping; remove wide unused fields.
- Filter the lookup source where the business rule allows it.
- Check lookup key uniqueness and source query performance.
- Evaluate supported pushdown or database join alternatives.
- Measure cache mode and concurrent jobs before changing runtime capacity.
- Do not disable cache blindly; repeated source queries may be slower.

Interviewer: Lookup fails with out-of-memory only in production. What is your plan?

Strong answer: Compare production row count/width, concurrent jobs, cache mode, agent memory, lookup query, and key uniqueness. Reduce columns/rows, optimize the source, evaluate supported pushdown/join alternatives, and increase capacity only if measurements justify it.

Interviewer: When use dynamic cache?

Strong answer: When rows in the same run need to update cache state so later rows can find inserted/changed records, such as certain dimension-maintenance patterns. It is not a generic speed switch.

Interviewer: Can a SQL window function be used directly inside an IDMC Expression after Lookup?

Strong answer: Not automatically. Support depends on the transformation, expression language/mode, and execution engine. Prepare the lookup source with SQL ranking, use supported Rank logic, or shape the source to expose one current row per business key.

Interviewer: What if Lookup returns multiple matches?

Strong answer: Do not depend on arbitrary first-row behavior. Enforce unique lookup keys or define a deterministic ranking rule and verify the product's duplicate-match behavior.

11. SCD Type 1 and Type 2

11.1 Type 1 versus Type 2

Event	Type 1	Type 2
Attribute change	Overwrite current value	Expire old version and insert new version

Historical reporting	Old value not retained in that row	Historical values retained
Complexity	Lower	Higher; dates, version keys, current flags
Typical use	Correction of a typo	Track historical changes in customer segment/address

Common SCD2 columns: surrogate key, business key, EFFECTIVE_FROM, EFFECTIVE_TO, IS_CURRENT, and optionally a change hash/source timestamp.

11.2 SCD2 processing flow

17. Standardize incoming business keys and tracked attributes.
18. Lookup the current dimension row by business key and current flag/effective date.
19. Compare tracked attributes or a deterministic hash with NULL-safe logic.
20. Route new, changed, unchanged, and invalid records separately.
21. For changed rows, expire the old version and insert a new version with a new surrogate key.
22. For new rows, insert the initial version.
23. Validate one current row per key, valid date ranges, key uniqueness, and expected counts.

```
-- No business key should have multiple current rows
SELECT CUSTOMER_ID, COUNT(*) AS CURRENT_ROWS
FROM PRODUCT_HISTORY
WHERE IS_CURRENT = 'Y'
GROUP BY CUSTOMER_ID
HAVING COUNT(*) > 1;

-- Inspect version chronology
SELECT *
FROM PRODUCT_HISTORY
ORDER BY CUSTOMER_ID, EFFECTIVE_FROM;

-- Invalid date ranges
SELECT *
FROM PRODUCT_HISTORY
WHERE EFFECTIVE_TO < EFFECTIVE_FROM;
```

Common defects: insert a new version without expiring the previous one; overwrite the old row's tracked attributes before inserting the new version; fail to define NULL transitions; process duplicate source keys nondeterministically.

Interviewer: How distinguish new, changed, and unchanged records?

Strong answer: Lookup by business key. No current match means new, subject to key-quality rules. A match with equal tracked attributes is unchanged. A match with different attributes is changed. Compare NULLs safely.

Interviewer: What if the same key appears twice in a batch?

Strong answer: Define whether the input is a snapshot or event stream. Deduplicate using a business-approved timestamp/sequence rule, or process events in deterministic order if every change matters. Otherwise multiple rows may create conflicting versions.

Interviewer: How prove SCD2 correctness?

Strong answer: Test new, changed, unchanged, duplicate, NULL-to-value, value-to-NULL, and deletion cases. Check exactly one current row per key, old-row expiration, new effective date, no unnecessary versions, and correct chronology.

12. Pushdown Optimization

Pushdown Optimization delegates supported transformation processing from the IDMC runtime to a source or target database/platform. It can reduce data movement and use database compute, but not every transformation or connector operation is pushdown-compatible.

12.1 Your practice flow

The exercise used SALES_SOURCE → Filter positive sales → Expression → Aggregator by region → REGION_SALES_TARGET, with PDO_TRAINING_DB.PUBLIC and PDO_TRAINING_WH.

```
-- Conceptual equivalent of pushed-down logic
SELECT REGION, SUM(SALES_AMOUNT) AS REGION_SALES
FROM PDO_TRAINING_DB.PUBLIC.SALES_SOURCE
WHERE SALES_AMOUNT > 0
GROUP BY REGION;
```

12.2 Verify actual pushdown

24. Check mapping/task pushdown settings and supported transformations.
25. Inspect session/job logs for generated SQL and pushdown decisions.
26. Inspect Snowflake Query History during the mapping execution window.
27. Compare rows read, rows transferred, rows written, elapsed time, and resource use.
28. Compare output with baseline SQL to prove semantic equivalence.

Interviewer: Pushdown is enabled but performance does not improve. Why?

Strong answer: It may not have occurred, only some transformations may have pushed, source volume may be small, SQL may be inefficient, or Snowflake may be queued/undersized. Inspect generated SQL, Query Profile, and row transfer; measure before and after.

Interviewer: Would you always enable full pushdown?

Strong answer: No. Support, connector compatibility, semantics, error handling, database load, and actual query plan matter. Test supported modes, validate results, and compare end-to-end performance.

13. Taskflows, Bronze/Silver/Gold, Restartability

13.1 Mapping, Mapping Task, Taskflow

Item	Purpose
Mapping	Defines transformation/data flow.
Mapping Task	Configures execution of the mapping.
Taskflow	Orchestrates tasks, dependencies, branching, and failure handling.

13.2 Layered pipeline

Layer	Responsibility	Validation
Bronze / Raw	Preserve source-shaped data and ingestion metadata	File/row counts, schema, load time, rejected rows.
Silver / Staging	Clean, standardize, validate, deduplicate, conform	NULL/invalid counts, duplicate keys, normalization.
Gold / Curated	Business-ready facts/dimensions, SCD, analytics columns	Uniqueness, referential integrity, reconciliation, KPIs.

Your customer pipeline used two mappings: M_CUSTOMER_SOURCE_TO_STAGING and M_CUSTOMER_STAGING_TO_GOLD, with Mapping Tasks and a sequential Taskflow plus decision-based success/failure routing.

13.3 Customer data quality rules

- Trim names, emails, and categorical fields.
- Lowercase email if the business standard requires it.
- Normalize segment/status to a controlled vocabulary.
- Define a policy for NULL/blank CUSTOMER_ID: reject, quarantine, or valid business-approved alternative.
- Deduplicate CUSTOMER_ID with an explicit winner rule.

- Keep invalid/rejected rows visible with reason codes; do not silently drop them.

13.4 Failure handling and idempotency

Restartability means a pipeline can resume or rerun after failure without losing data or creating duplicates. Use batch IDs, checkpoints/watermarks, idempotent writes, deterministic merge keys, audit records, and a documented recovery procedure.

Interviewer: Design a taskflow for two dependent mappings.

Strong answer: Run mapping one, capture status and metrics, and branch only on confirmed success. Run mapping two only after success. On failure, audit and alert through approved mechanisms and block downstream publication. Make reruns safe and validate partial-completion behavior.

Interviewer: The pipeline fails after staging but before Gold. What prevents duplicates on rerun?

Strong answer: Batch-scoped staging writes or replacement logic, idempotent Gold MERGE/upsert, run identifiers/checkpoints, and validation queries. Simply rerunning is not a recovery strategy.

14. Snowpark, Streamlit, Cortex Analyst

14.1 Snowpark DataFrames

Snowpark lets Python express transformations that Snowflake can execute. DataFrame transformations are generally lazy: they build a logical plan. Actions such as show, collect, count, or write trigger execution, depending on the operation and API version.

```
from snowflake.snowpark.functions import col, datediff

bookings = session.table("BOOKINGS_CURATED")
bookings = bookings.with_column(
    "NIGHTS",
    datediff("DAY", col("CHECKIN_DATE"), col("CHECKOUT_DATE"))
)
bookings = bookings.with_column(
    "GROSS_AMOUNT",
    col("NIGHTS") * col("ROOM_RATE")
)
bookings.show()
```

Validate date order, NULL dates, zero-night stays, currency precision, cancellation/refund rules, and business definitions before treating gross amount as net revenue.

14.2 session.sql()

```
# Prefer one SQL statement per call
session.sql("CREATE OR REPLACE TABLE TRAINING_DB.PUBLIC.DEMO (ID INTEGER)").collect()
session.sql("INSERT INTO TRAINING_DB.PUBLIC.DEMO (ID) VALUES (100)").collect()
session.table("TRAINING_DB.PUBLIC.DEMO").show()
```

session.sql() is not a general multi-statement SQL script runner. Separate DDL/DML intentionally and confirm execution behavior for your Snowpark version. Merely constructing a DataFrame is not always the same as executing it.

14.3 Streamlit and Cortex Analyst

- Push filtering and aggregation to Snowflake rather than collecting large fact tables into local Python memory.
- Use clear KPI definitions and handle empty filters, NULL metrics, date ranges, and zero denominators.
- Do not expose credentials in notebooks or source control. Use supported connection/session patterns.
- For Cortex Analyst, define grain, relationships, measure semantics, and date roles. Inspect generated SQL when answers are wrong.

Flight-booking object	Modeling role
FACT_BOOKING	Booking grain, measures, and foreign keys must be explicit.

DIM_DATE	Calendar attributes; clarify booking date versus departure/check-in date.
DIM_FLIGHT	Carrier, route, flight details.
DIM_PASSENGER	Passenger attributes; apply privacy/access controls.

Interviewer: Cortex Analyst returns a plausible but wrong revenue number. What do you do?

Strong answer: Inspect generated SQL, measure definition, fact grain, join cardinality, date role, refund/cancellation logic, and semantic model relationships. Compare with a verified query on a controlled subset and correct the model/data.

Interviewer: Why avoid collect() on a large table?

Strong answer: It transfers rows to the client and can exhaust memory or create unnecessary network transfer. Filter and aggregate in Snowflake, collecting only small results needed by Python/UI.

15. Troubleshooting Playbook

15.1 Universal diagnostic sequence

29. Reproduce with known input and define expected output.
30. Identify the layer: source, connector, transformation, runtime, target, orchestration, security, or platform.
31. Read the first meaningful error and inspect logs before changing settings.
32. Check counts, key uniqueness, NULLs, datatypes, schema, parameters, and permissions.
33. Isolate with a minimal test: one row, one key, one file, or one SQL statement.
34. Change one variable at a time and record evidence.
35. Validate business correctness and recovery after the fix.

Symptom	First checks	Avoid
Valid mapping, zero rows	Source count, filters, lookup/join paths, runtime connection, target context	Assuming validation guarantees data flow.
Lookup memory error	Lookup row width/count, cache mode, concurrent jobs, agent memory	Blindly disabling cache.
Pushdown no gain	Generated SQL, Query History/Profile, rows transferred	Claiming it worked because job succeeded.
COPY loads zero	Stage path/LIST, file format, load history, already-loaded file	Randomly changing parsing options.
Task not running	Resume state, schedule, condition, dependencies, grants, history	Recreating before diagnosis.
SCD2 duplicate current rows	Source duplicates, expire path, current lookup, rerun behavior	Manually patching rows but leaving logic broken.
Join doubles totals	Join cardinality, grain, duplicate keys, effective dates	Adding DISTINCT to hide multiplication.
Snowpark statement error	Separate SQL statements, execution action, object names, privileges	Passing a multi-statement script to one call.
REST V2 zero rows	HTTP body/status, pagination, response path, auth, filters, schema mapping	Assuming green status means records loaded.

15.2 REST V2 zero-row checklist

- Confirm the endpoint returns records using the same credentials and execution context.
- Inspect response status/body, pagination/next-page behavior, and continuation tokens.
- Verify the response array/path and field projection match the actual response shape.
- Check query parameters, date filters, watermarks, and whether an empty response is expected.
- Check schema drift, datatype conversion, rejected records, and target mappings.
- Compare records received, rows parsed, rows transformed, rows rejected, and rows written.

15.3 Common error mindset

Record run ID, timestamp, runtime/agent, connection, object, SQL if available, and the smallest reproducible input. Avoid sharing secrets, tokens, or personal data in logs or interview examples.

16. Scenario-Based Mock Interview Bank

Answer aloud before reading the reasoning path. Expect follow-up constraints. A strong candidate makes assumptions explicit, identifies evidence, and validates the final state.

Scenario 1: Mapping succeeds, target empty

Scenario: REST V2 mapping validates and reports success, but target is empty.

Reasoning path: Inspect endpoint response and pagination, response path, source count, filters, lookup/join paths, target mapping, write mode, logs, and rejected rows. Find the boundary where rows disappear; reproduce with a known response.

What this tests: Connector behavior and layered diagnostics.

Scenario 2: Production Lookup runs out of memory

Scenario: Lookup works on a small test but fails on production volume.

Reasoning path: Compare lookup row count/width, active caches, cache mode, concurrent jobs, agent memory, query performance, and key uniqueness. Reduce columns/rows, evaluate pushdown/join alternatives, then resize capacity if evidence supports it.

What this tests: Cache mechanics and trade-offs.

Scenario 3: SCD2 has two current rows

Scenario: Several business keys now have multiple rows marked current.

Reasoning path: Inspect duplicate source keys, current-row lookup, change route, expiration update, insert path, transaction behavior, and reruns. Reproduce with one key and enforce a validation query.

What this tests: Full SCD reasoning rather than patching.

Scenario 4: Revenue doubles after a join

Scenario: Booking revenue is nearly twice expected.

Reasoning path: Check fact grain, dimension uniqueness, historical versions, join cardinality, and row counts/sums before and after each join. Fix join semantics, not symptoms.

What this tests: Data modeling and many-to-many joins.

Scenario 5: Query slows as table grows

Scenario: A Snowflake query moves from seconds to minutes.

Reasoning path: Compare profiles and data volume; inspect pruning, scan bytes, joins, spills, queue time, and warehouse. Improve filters/query shape before adding clustering or resizing blindly.

What this tests: Evidence-led performance tuning.

Scenario 6: Stream empty after source update

Scenario: Developer updates source, but stream query returns no rows.

Reasoning path: Verify correct stream/source, tracking, offset, transaction commit, whether another consumer advanced it, and source replacement/recreation. Check task history.

What this tests: Offsets and transactional consumption.

Scenario 7: Task never executes

Scenario: Task exists but target never changes.

Reasoning path: Check resume state, schedule, WHEN condition, dependencies, grants, warehouse/serverless setup, and task history. Test underlying SQL separately.

What this tests: Operational detail beyond syntax.

Scenario 8: COPY sees no new rows

Scenario: File exists in object storage, but load produces zero rows.

Reasoning path: Verify integration, stage path, LIST, pattern, format, target context, load history, previous load metadata, and rejected rows.

What this tests: Ingestion layer isolation.

Scenario 9: Pushdown enabled but no improvement

Scenario: Secure Agent remains busy and Snowflake shows little query activity.

Reasoning path: Inspect generated SQL/logs, unsupported transformations, mode, source/target constraints, and actual query history. Compare data transfer and elapsed time.

What this tests: Configured versus actual pushdown.

Scenario 10: Duplicate business key in batch

Scenario: Two records for key 42 contain different emails.

Reasoning path: Clarify snapshot versus event semantics. Select by source sequence/timestamp/priority or process events in order. Record duplicate counts and rejected cases.

What this tests: Business rules and determinism.

Scenario 11: Masking blocks analyst

Scenario: An analyst who should see email gets masked values.

Reasoning path: Check active role, hierarchy, policy logic, attachment, datatypes, role names, and governance rule. Test with explicit roles.

What this tests: Security debugging.

Scenario 12: Snowpark insert appears missing

Scenario: Developer sends CREATE, INSERT, SELECT in one session.sql string.

Reasoning path: Split statements, execute each intentionally, verify database/schema/role/warehouse, inspect exceptions, then query the table.

What this tests: API and statement execution behavior.

Scenario 13: Rerun duplicates data

Scenario: Taskflow failed after staging but before Gold; operator reruns.

Reasoning path: Use batch IDs, idempotent stage writes, deterministic MERGE keys, checkpoints, and audit state. Verify rerun does not duplicate keys.

What this tests: Restartability.

Scenario 14: Dynamic Table misses freshness target

Scenario: Actual freshness is worse than the business SLA.

Reasoning path: Inspect target lag, refresh history, upstream dependencies, query profile, supported incremental behavior, and resource constraints. Simplify query or revisit target lag/architecture based on evidence.

What this tests: Freshness trade-offs.

Scenario 15: Snowpipe delay

Scenario: Files arrive in object storage, but target data is late.

Reasoning path: Check notifications, integration permissions, stage/prefix, pipe status, load history, file size/pattern, and downstream transformation lag. Separate event delay from load failure.

What this tests: End-to-end latency diagnosis.

Scenario 16: Silver has invalid customer records

Scenario: Blank IDs, malformed emails, inconsistent status values.

Reasoning path: Define business validation rules, normalize fields, quarantine invalid records with reason codes, deduplicate deterministically, publish quality metrics, and gate Gold if thresholds fail.

What this tests: Governed data quality.

Scenario 17: Snowflake costs double

Scenario: New pipeline sharply increases credits.

Reasoning path: Attribute spend by warehouse/query/task. Check auto-suspend, retry loops, warehouse size, repeated full refreshes/scans, and SQL shape. Add cost controls and measure cost per successful batch.

What this tests: Cost accountability.

Scenario 18: Cortex Analyst uses wrong date

Scenario: Question about flight date returns revenue for booking date.

Reasoning path: Clarify intended date role, inspect semantic relationships and generated SQL, verify date dimension joins and measure definition, and add clear descriptions/examples.

What this tests: Semantic ambiguity.

Scenario 19: Late-arriving update

Scenario: Older source timestamp arrives after a newer version was loaded.

Reasoning path: Determine event time versus arrival time and whether historical correction is required. Use sequence/version rules, reject stale events if appropriate, or reconstruct effective intervals for corrections.

What this tests: Temporal data correctness.

Scenario 20: Dev and production counts differ

Scenario: Same mapping returns 100k rows in dev and 97k in prod.

Reasoning path: Compare source snapshots, parameters, schema/connection, filters, permissions, runtime/connector versions, lookup data, rejects, and target mode. Trace counts at each boundary and reconcile keys.

What this tests: Controlled comparison.

17. Rapid-Fire Questions and Final Checklist

Interviewer: Snowpipe versus COPY INTO?

Strong answer: COPY INTO supports controlled load workflows and batch/backfill. Snowpipe supports managed continuous ingestion.

Interviewer: Streams versus Time Travel?

Strong answer: Streams expose changes since an offset for incremental processing. Time Travel accesses historical object data within retention.

Interviewer: Task versus Dynamic Table?

Strong answer: Task runs scheduled/conditioned SQL or procedures with explicit orchestration. Dynamic Table declaratively maintains a query result toward a target lag.

Interviewer: Masking versus row access?

Strong answer: Masking changes column visibility; row access controls which rows are visible.

Interviewer: Temporary versus transient?

Strong answer: Temporary is session-scoped; transient persists but lacks Fail-safe protection.

Interviewer: Mapping versus Mapping Task versus Taskflow?

Strong answer: Mapping defines data flow; Mapping Task configures execution; Taskflow orchestrates tasks and branches.

Interviewer: Static versus dynamic Lookup cache?

Strong answer: Static cache is not updated row-by-row; dynamic cache can be updated during supported processing patterns.

Interviewer: Why is SCD2 harder than SCD1?

Strong answer: It must preserve historical versions, expire old rows, insert new versions, and maintain one current row per key.

Interviewer: What is idempotency?

Strong answer: Replaying the same operation produces the intended state without unintended duplicates or inconsistent side effects.

Interviewer: Why might a cached Lookup still be slow?

Strong answer: Cache build time, cache size, memory pressure, source query cost, concurrency, and downstream processing can dominate.

Interviewer: Why avoid a larger warehouse as the first fix?

Strong answer: It costs more and cannot repair every bottleneck; diagnose scan, pruning, join cardinality, spill, queueing, and SQL shape.

Interviewer: How do you prove a pipeline is correct?

Strong answer: Reconcile counts and business keys at each boundary, test inserts/updates/deletes/NULLs/duplicates, inspect rejects, and validate target invariants.

Final Readiness Checklist

- ☐ Explain Snowflake storage/compute/cloud services, warehouse scaling, micro-partitions, and pruning.
- ☐ Load CSV data using stages, file formats, COPY INTO, and load history.
- ☐ Distinguish COPY, Snowpipe, Streams, Tasks, and Dynamic Tables.
- ☐ Explain stream offsets and CDC metadata; write a safe MERGE.
- ☐ Compare table types, Time Travel, Fail-safe, and cloning.
- ☐ Use Query Profile and monitoring surfaces to diagnose performance/cost.
- ☐ Explain RBAC, masking policies, and row access policies.
- ☐ Explain IDMC architecture, mappings, Mapping Tasks, Taskflows, and Secure Agent.
- ☐ Diagnose a successful mapping with zero rows.
- ☐ Explain Expression, Filter, Router, Aggregator, Joiner, Sorter, Rank, and Lookup.
- ☐ Compare connected/unconnected Lookup and cache types.
- ☐ Diagnose Lookup cache memory errors with evidence.
- ☐ Design SCD1/SCD2 and validate current-row/date-range invariants.
- ☐ Explain how to verify actual Pushdown Optimization.
- ☐ Design restartable Bronze/Silver/Gold pipelines.
- ☐ Explain Snowpark lazy execution and why large collect() calls are risky.
- ☐ Diagnose incorrect metrics in fact/dimension models or Cortex Analyst.
- ☐ Answer at least ten scenarios aloud without reading the reasoning path.

Glossary

Term	Meaning
CDC	Change Data Capture: identifying inserts, updates, deletes for incremental processing.
SCD	Slowly Changing Dimension: handling changes to dimension attributes.
ETL / ELT	Transform before load / transform after load.
RBAC	Role-Based Access Control.
Pushdown	Delegating supported transformation work to the database/platform.
Watermark	Saved timestamp/sequence boundary used to identify new source

	data.
Idempotency	Safe replay without unintended duplicates or inconsistent state.
Grain	The event/entity represented by one table row.
Pruning	Skipping irrelevant partitions/data during query execution.
Target lag	Dynamic Table freshness objective, not a promise of instantaneous refresh.
Quarantine	Controlled storage for invalid records and their rejection reasons.

Official documentation to consult before production changes

Use current Snowflake documentation for Streams and offsets, Tasks/task graphs, Dynamic Tables, COPY INTO/COPY_HISTORY, Snowpipe, Time Travel/Fail-safe, Query Profile, access control, masking/row access policies, Snowpark Python, and Cortex Analyst. Use your IDMC tenant's current documentation for the exact connector, Lookup/cache behavior, Pushdown Optimization support matrix, Secure Agent runtime, Mapping Tasks, and Taskflows. Connector and release details can differ.

This guide is designed to train reasoning and interview performance. It is not a substitute for release-specific product documentation or your organization's production standards.